

EVEN-TOED UNGULATES

One of two orders of hoofed mammals, the Artiodactyla stand on two or four toes. Most are herbivorous, and have a multi-chambered, fermenting stomach.

Even-toed ungulates are often described as cloven hoofed. This is because the tip of each toe has its own hoof – a hard, rubbery, sole surrounded by a thick nail. The hoof wears down through use, but grows continually. Only the camelids lack hoofs – although they walk on two toes, the hoof is reduced to a small nail.

CHEWING THE CUD

With long legs and their feet protected with hoofs, even-toed ungulates often range extensively across grassland and forested habitats in search of food. Most families are grazers of grass and herbs or browsers of shoots and leaves. Their digestive system is well adapted to a diet of tough vegetable matter: the stomach has three or four chambers and contains bacteria that digest the cellulose in plant cell walls, releasing nutrients inside. To help with this, partly digested food (cud) is regurgitated for further chewing, a process

known as rumination. Artiodactyls also have large, broad cheek teeth to grind up their tough food, and long intestines. Pigs and peccaries are somewhat different: they do not ruminate, have more generalized teeth, and a more omnivorous diet. Sometimes the canine teeth are enlarged into tusks for defence, fighting, and rooting for food.

DOMESTICATION

Introduced into Australasia, members of this order are found on every continent except Antarctica. They vary greatly in shape and in size, with shoulder height ranging from 20 cm (8 in) in the mouse-deer to almost 4 m (13 ft) in the giraffe. Many species are hunted in the wild as food by humans, but others have been domesticated and are economically important – cattle, llamas, sheep, and pigs are used for meat, leather, wool, dairy products, and transport. Domestication has given rise to animal breeds with a distinctive appearance that matches their specific purpose.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	MAMMALIA
ORDER	ARTIODACTYLA
FAMILIES	10
SPECIES	384

DEBATE

ONE SPECIES OR MORE?

During the last ten years, over 100 new bovid species have been described, often because taxonomists, scientists who classify things, have categorized different races (subspecies) of certain bovids as species in their own right. Genetic evidence is used to substantiate (or sometimes refute) these divisions. Giraffes, for example, were previously described as a single species containing a number of subspecies. However, recent DNA evidence supports their division into four species – the Masai (*G. tippelskirchi*), reticulated (*G. reticulata*), northern (*G. camelopardalis*; three subspecies), and southern giraffes (*G. giraffa* ; two subspecies).

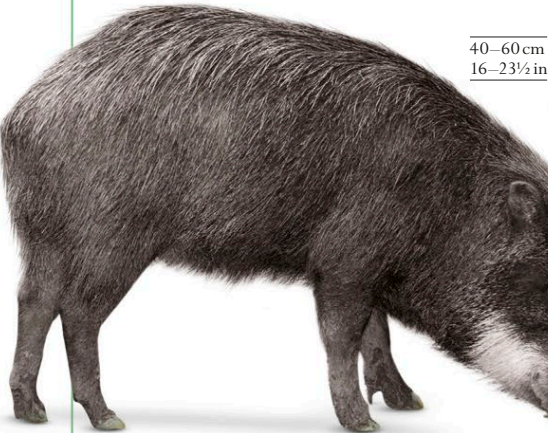
PECCARIES

Found in the Americas, the Tayassuidae share many features with pigs, such as small eyes and a snout that ends in a cartilaginous disc. But they have a more complex, chambered stomach, and short, straight tusks.



CHACOAN PECCARY
Catagonus wagneri

Found in the Chaco ecoregion of central S. America, this large peccary was first described from fossils, and was discovered to be a living species only in 1975.



WHITE-LIPPED PECCARY
Tayassu pecari

Living in large herds in C. and S. America, this species will group together and face-off a predator, but they are fast and will flee if necessary.



COLLARED PECCARY
Pecari tajacu

Widespread in the tropical and subtropical Americas, this diurnal pig is extremely social in nature. It is considered destructive in agricultural areas, as it often raids crops.